

Question 29 · Unit 2 · 8 Marks

An organisation has an appraisal system but employees report that it does not help their development. Apply HRD principles to improve the appraisal process.

Introduction

This is an application question. Do not write a general essay ‘appraisal is important’. The organisation already has a system; employees say it does not develop them. Typical reasons: it is only for increment; ratings are secret or surprising; no counselling; no follow-up; managers are untrained; climate is fearful; no link to training or career. Apply HRD principles (purpose, participation, line skill, integration, climate, continuity, evaluation) to redesign the process.

Detailed points

- 1. Clarify purpose in policy and in every meeting.** State in writing that the primary purpose of this appraisal is development — understanding performance and planning growth. Rewards may use some of the same data, but the conversation is about improvement. Mixed messages (‘fill this for increment’) are why employees feel it does not help. Principle: developmental purpose.
- 2. Begin with role clarity and jointly set goals.** If employees never agreed key result areas, the review feels unfair and random. At the start of the period, boss and employee set goals and expected behaviours. Principle: participation and fairness.
- 3. Train managers in evidence-based feedback.** Replace labels (‘average’, ‘attitude problem’) with incidents and impact. Teach listening. Untrained bosses are a main reason appraisal does not develop anyone. Principle: line managers as developers need skill.
- 4. Protect a real counselling conversation.** Ban signing forms in the corridor. Give a quiet time slot. Two-way talk: employee’s self-appraisal first. Keep criticism on performance, not character. Confidentiality. Principle: counselling is the heart of HRD appraisal.
- 5. End with an individual development plan and follow-up dates.** Two or three actions — coaching, a course, a project — with dates, reviewed after a quarter. Without this, the meeting was judgement, not development. Principle: continuity.
- 6. Link appraisal to training, career and potential.** Gaps go to TNA. Aspirations go to career discussion. High performers with leadership behaviours go to potential review. Employees will start to feel the system helps when something actually happens after the form. Principle: integration.
- 7. Climate safeguards.** No public humiliation of ratings. Some appeal on process. Fair standards across bosses (moderation). Fearless data is better data. Principle: HRD climate.
- 8. Evaluate the appraisal process itself.** Once a year ask employees: did this review help you develop? Hold managers accountable for quality of conversations, not only for submitting forms on time. Redesign what hinders the HRD process. Principle: evaluation.

Conclusion. Apply principles as a redesign: purpose, joint goals, trained feedback, counselling time, IDP, links to other subsystems, climate safeguards, and evaluation of appraisal itself. Do not invent a new form colour and call it HRD. Employees will say appraisal helps only when something developmental follows the discussion.